

Online Presence, Press, SEO, and Scam Vocabulary

A consolidated reference guide covering entity building, distribution, publicity, reputation, provenance, search manipulation, deceptive marketing, and con anatomy.

How to use this guide

These terms describe mechanisms rather than automatically assigning intent. A high-volume online footprint can be legitimate distribution and documentation; it becomes problematic when it creates a material false impression about identity, independence, proof, popularity, credentials, price, consent, or accountability.

Practical rule: distinguish owned records, paid placements, syndicated copies, database listings, and independently earned editorial coverage. A single press release appearing on 50 sites is one originating source with many mirrors, not 50 independent validations.

How a Name Appears Everywhere

Entity bootstrapping	Rapidly establishing a person, artist, brand, or project as a recognizable online entity through consistent profiles, metadata, listings, pages, and references.
Digital footprint seeding	Creating an initial distributed trail of profiles, directories, bios, credits, and platform pages so a person or project is discoverable.
Presence engineering	Informal term for deliberately designing a broad, coherent web presence instead of relying on one platform.
Entity stacking	Building mutually reinforcing records around one name: official site, social accounts, databases, releases, directories, interviews, and announcements.
Identity infrastructure	The ethical version of a broad presence: accurate, connected records of real work, credits, contact information, and official channels.
Synthetic presence	A public footprint whose apparent organic reach exceeds the real-world activity behind it, often through automation, paid placement, fake engagement, or low-quality replication.
Reputation seeding	Placing early factual records that establish a discoverable identity; problematic only when it creates false third-party validation.
Entity laundering	Informal term for coordinated listings and apparently independent pages that manufacture the appearance of an established public figure, brand, or expert.
Syndication cascade	One source item spreads outward through feeds, mirrors, aggregators, republishers, snippets, and scrapers.
Boilerplate propagation	A bio, quote, credential paragraph, or company description is repeated unchanged across profiles and pages.

Entity, Identity, and Metadata

Entity	A distinct person, organization, project, work, place, or concept that a system can identify and connect.
Entity resolution	Matching references across sites to determine that they refer to the same real-world entity.
Entity reconciliation	Correcting, merging, or aligning conflicting records for the same entity.
Entity disambiguation	Separating two similarly named people, bands, studios, or businesses.
Entity salience	How clearly a page is about an entity, rather than merely mentioning it.
Entity confidence	Informal term for the strength of evidence that connected profiles and records refer to the same thing.
Canonical identity	The definitive name, bio, image, website, and official-profile set for a person or project.
Canonical source	The original or authoritative page from which facts should derive.
Canonical URL	The preferred representative URL among duplicate or very similar pages.
Canonicalization	The process by which a search engine selects a representative URL for duplicated or closely similar content.
Name normalization	Keeping spelling, punctuation, capitalization, aliases, and ordering consistent across platforms.
Alias management	Documenting stage names, former names, side projects, imprints, and abbreviations so their relationships are clear.
Identity graph	The network of pages, accounts, credits, releases, organizations, and collaborators connected to an identity.
Identity claim	Asserting control over an existing platform profile or listing.
Identity proofing	A platform's process for validating that a claimant represents a person or organization.
Source-of-truth page	A maintained official hub containing current factual information that press, platforms, and audiences can cite.
Officialness signal	A feature indicating that a profile is authoritative, such as verified status, a linked domain, or consistent official accounts.
Same-as linkage	Declaring that external profiles belong to the same person or organization, often through structured data.
Knowledge graph	A structured network connecting entities and their relationships.
Knowledge panel	A search-result information panel assembled from entity data; it is not independent press coverage.

Entity home	Informal term for the main owned web location defining an entity.
Entity drift	Public descriptions becoming inconsistent, outdated, inflated, or confused with another entity.
Entity collision	Two entities being conflated because of shared or similar names, metadata, art, or domains.
Identity fragmentation	One creator or organization appearing as multiple unconnected records because metadata or credits do not align.
Metadata hygiene	Accurate, consistent maintenance of titles, credits, dates, rights data, identifiers, images, genres, URLs, and biographies.

Press, Publicity, and Placement

Earned media	Unpaid editorial coverage independently chosen by a journalist, critic, editor, curator, or producer.
Owned media	Channels controlled by the subject: a website, newsletter, press room, social accounts, Bandcamp, YouTube, or EPK.
Paid media	Visibility purchased through advertising, sponsorship, promoted posts, or media buying.
Shared media	Conversation, redistribution, and engagement occurring in communities and social platforms.
PESO model	A communications framework grouping Paid, Earned, Shared, and Owned media.
Press release	A subject-originated announcement intended for media use; it is not a reported article.
Media advisory	A concise logistical alert about an event, launch, premiere, or media opportunity.
Press kit / EPK	A package of approved facts, images, bios, work samples, credits, links, and contact information.
Media list	A targeted database of journalists, editors, critics, curators, bloggers, radio hosts, and producers.
Media pitch	A tailored argument for why a particular outlet or writer should cover a story.
Pitch angle	The particular framing that makes an announcement relevant to a given outlet or audience.
News hook	The timely, unusual, local, culturally relevant, or consequential reason a story merits coverage now.
Embargo	A request that recipients not publish supplied information until a stated date and time.
Exclusive	First access to a story, premiere, interview, work, or announcement offered to one outlet.
Premiere placement	An outlet debuting a track, video, film, essay, or project ahead of wider release.
Press cycle	The planned sequence of announcements, pitches, coverage, follow-up, and assets around a release.
Media relations	Relationship-building and communication with editors, writers, producers, critics, and outlets.
Publicity	The broader practice of generating public awareness and coverage.
Press clipping	A saved article, review, segment, feature, or meaningful mention.
Clip book	A portfolio or archive of press clippings.
Press mention	Any appearance of a name in a media outlet; it is not automatically endorsement or coverage.
Byline	The named author of a published piece.
Syndicated pickup / wire pickup	A republication of supplied material through a wire or syndication network, rather than an independent editorial decision.
Churnalism	Publication built substantially from press releases or supplied material with little original reporting.
Advertorial	Promotional content presented in editorial style.
Sponsored editorial	Paid article-like content that should be clearly disclosed.
Partner content	A broad label for commercially affiliated, co-produced, or sponsored publishing.
Native advertising	An ad designed to match the format and visual style of surrounding editorial content.

Paid placement	Payment for a feature, ranking, interview, inclusion, or exposure.
Pay-to-play press	A model where the subject pays directly or indirectly for coverage.
Vanity press	A publisher or outlet that charges the subject for publication while selling an appearance of prestige.
PR mill	A high-volume service selling generic distribution, placements, or superficial coverage at scale.
Vanity music blog	A music or culture outlet selling flattering artist features that imitate independent editorial attention.
Prestige mimicry	Names, layouts, logos, or language engineered to evoke more established institutions.
Masthead cosplay	Informal term for a site that performs the look of a publication without accountable editorial process or real reporting.
Media-logo laundering	Using outlet logos to imply endorsement or major coverage when the relationship was a minor mention, wire pickup, or paid placement.
Earned-media inflation	Presenting paid, owned, syndicated, and independent appearances as though all were earned press.

Syndication, Aggregation, and Publishing

Syndication	Authorized or automated republication of content across publishers, feeds, aggregators, or partners.
Syndication network	The set of platforms that ingest or relay material from a shared source.
Content feed	A machine-readable stream of updates, commonly RSS, Atom, XML, JSON, or an API.
RSS scraping	Automatically copying or displaying material from RSS feeds, sometimes with almost no added context.
Content scraping	Extracting material from another site and republishing it, with or without permission or attribution.
Mirroring	Creating a copy of a site, page, file, or collection at another address.
Replication	Reproduction of the same content across multiple systems.
Content ingestion	Importing third-party material into a platform, database, website, or publication workflow.
Content ingestion pipeline	An automated sequence that pulls, transforms, categorizes, stores, and publishes imported material.
Feed-to-page publishing	A system that turns feed entries directly into public, indexable pages.
Autoblogging	Automatically publishing material from feeds, scraping, APIs, summaries, or generative systems, usually at volume.
Programmatic publishing	Using templates plus data to produce pages at scale; legitimate when pages offer genuine, distinct utility.
Programmatic SEO	Creating templated pages to rank across large groups of searches, locations, products, or topics.
Scaled content	Large quantities of content; volume itself is not proof of low quality.
Scaled content abuse	High-volume production primarily intended to manipulate search results with unoriginal or low-value pages.
Near-duplicate content	Pages that overlap heavily but vary slightly by keyword, location, title, or product field.
Template sprawl	Informal term for a site bloated with thin pages made from the same basic structure.
Content spinning	Mechanical rewriting intended to make copied text look unique.
Article spinning	Content spinning specifically applied to articles, posts, or press releases.
Scraper site	A site whose primary content is copied from elsewhere, often without meaningful transformation.
Text injection	Unauthorized or automated insertion of text into an existing page.
Keyword injection	Adding target terms to page text, metadata, or hidden areas to attract search traffic.
Spam injection	Unauthorized insertion of links, pages, scripts, redirects, or keyword text, often on compromised sites.
Doorway page	A page made mainly to rank for a query and funnel visitors elsewhere rather than serve the query itself.

Search-result footprint	The collection of indexed URLs, snippets, images, panels, directories, and platform pages tied to a query.
SERP saturation	Occupying an unusually large portion of search results for a name or topic.
SERP real estate	The amount and quality of visible search-result space occupied or controlled by an entity.
Search-ecosystem propagation	The movement of a name, claim, release, or record through indexes, feeds, caches, aggregators, and snippets.
Indexation lag	The time between publication and search-engine discovery, processing, or indexing.
Deindexing	Removal of a URL or domain from a search engine's index.
Cache residue	An old copy, snippet, archive capture, preview, or result that persists after the live source changes or disappears.
Orphan page	A page with no internal links pointing to it from elsewhere on its own site.
Zombie page	An old, thin, redundant, outdated, or purposeless indexed page that remains live.

Search, Trust, and Reputation

Organic visibility	Being found through unpaid search results.
Branded search	A search for a specific person, artist, project, studio, or brand name.
Branded SERP	The search-results page for a particular name or brand.
Entity SEO	Making a truthful identity and its relationships easier for search systems to understand.
Reputation management	Monitoring, improving, correcting, and contextualizing public search results.
Reputation engineering	The broader, deliberate shaping of the public evidence trail around a name.
Reputation laundering	Creating an inflated or misleading aura of legitimacy through paid, automated, or weakly independent third-party signals.
Authority signal	A feature contributing to perceived credibility, such as a named author, relevant citation, quality link, editorial standards, or established profile.
Authority laundering	Borrowing institutional prestige without corresponding real validation.
Trust signal	A truthful risk-reducing feature such as clear contact information, credits, real policies, disclosures, or authentic reviews.
Trust theater	The appearance of safety, quality, transparency, or accountability without the operational reality.
Social proof	Evidence that other people have used, attended, bought, reviewed, or recommended something.
Proof stack	A marketer's collection of testimonials, demos, statistics, awards, clips, endorsements, and case studies.
Proof laundering	Making a weak signal seem like strong validation through repetition, design, or contextual manipulation.
Third-party validation	Credibility provided by an independent source with its own standards.
Third-party validation theater	Simulating outside endorsement using directories, paid badges, self-submitted awards, syndication, or friendly networks.
Citation velocity	The speed at which a person, brand, source, or claim begins gaining mentions or links.
Link velocity	The rate at which a page gains inbound links.
Link neighborhood	The quality, relevance, and trust characteristics of sites linking to a page.
Co-citation	Two entities being mentioned or linked together by outside sources.
Co-occurrence	Names or concepts appearing near each other in text, with or without links.
Semantic association	The topical relationships that systems infer between an entity and people, places, genres, or subjects.
Topical authority	Demonstrated depth and usefulness in a subject area; not mere content volume.

Brand query ownership	How well search results for a name represent the authentic project rather than irrelevant pages or impostors.
Search narrative	The story implied by the first pages of search results about an entity.
Reputational moat	A distributed base of authentic work, credible records, accurate profiles, and audience trust that makes impersonation or misinformation less persuasive.
Digital exhaust	The incidental trail of credits, listings, tags, archives, event pages, and platform records produced by activity.
Search residue	Old, duplicated, partial, or stale online traces that remain discoverable.

SEO Abuse and Low-Trust Publishing

SEO spam / search spam	Content or techniques made chiefly to manipulate rankings rather than help users.
Spamdexing	Older term for manipulating search-engine indexes through deceptive SEO.
Cloaking	Showing search crawlers materially different content from what human visitors see.
Sneaky redirect	Redirecting users or crawlers to an unexpected destination deceptively.
Hidden text	Text concealed from typical visitors but intended for crawlers.
Hidden links	Concealed links added to influence ranking signals.
Keyword stuffing	Unnatural repetition of keywords to influence relevance signals.
Keyword cannibalization	A site's own legitimate pages competing for the same query; an architecture problem, not inherently spam.
Link scheme	Links bought, exchanged, automated, or arranged mainly to manipulate rankings.
Link farm	A network of sites created to manufacture or exchange backlinks.
Private blog network (PBN)	A controlled network of sites used primarily to place links and pass apparent authority to another site.
Expired-domain abuse	Repurposing an expired domain chiefly to exploit authority created by its prior owner and rank low-value material.
Domain hijacking	Unauthorized takeover of a domain, registrar account, or DNS configuration.
Typosquatting	Registering misspelled or visually similar domains to divert traffic or imitate a brand.
Combo-squatting	Adding plausible words to a known brand in a domain, such as "brand-support" or "brand-login."
Subdomain abuse	Using subdomains on a trusted root domain to host unrelated or abusive material.
Subfolder abuse	Similar misuse through folders on a trusted domain.
Parasite SEO	Informal term for exploiting another site's authority to rank third-party content.
Site-reputation abuse	Third-party content published mainly to exploit a host site's ranking signals, often with limited oversight.
Content farm	High-volume, low-cost publishing intended to harvest traffic, advertising, affiliate revenue, or rankings.
Made-for-advertising (MFA) site	A site built primarily to generate ad impressions, commonly using thin material and aggressive ad layouts.
Pink-slime outlet	A journalism-looking local or civic-information outlet using opaque funding, automation, outsourcing, partisanship, or weak editorial accountability.
Hacked-content spam	Spam pages, text, or links inserted into a legitimate site after unauthorized access.
Injected spam	Unauthorized content, links, scripts, or redirects on a site.
Japanese keyword hack	A common hacked-site SEO pattern involving autogenerated pages targeting Japanese-language queries.
Pharma hack	A compromised-site pattern that adds pharmaceutical keywords, pages, or links to capture search traffic.
Cloaked spam page	A page that appears benign to site owners or ordinary users while delivering spam content to crawlers or selected visitors.

Gibberish spam	Nonsensical or machine-generated text produced to appear unique enough for indexing.
Scraped-and-spun content	Copied material mechanically rewritten to evade duplicate-content detection.
Page hijacking	Making a page appear in search results for another site's content or mimicking a real page to divert traffic.
Negative SEO	Attempts to harm a competitor's search standing through malicious links, hacked content, copied pages, or fake reports; often alleged too casually.
Index bloat	Too many low-value, redundant, parameterized, thin, or duplicate URLs indexed on a site.
Crawl budget waste	Crawler effort spent on low-value URLs instead of important pages.
Canonicalization failure	A search engine indexes or ranks an unintended duplicate rather than the preferred original.
Canonical tag abuse	Misusing canonical tags in an attempt to transfer relevance or authority deceptively.
Orphaned spam page	A spam page with no visible internal links, often discoverable only through search, sitemaps, archives, or logs.

Provenance, OSINT, and Verification

Provenance	The origin and chain of custody of information, images, quotes, or claims.
Source trace	The path backward from a current page to the earliest identifiable origin.
Origin point	The earliest known publication or source of a specific statement.
Primary source	Direct original evidence such as an interview, recording, filing, full study, or first-hand document.
Secondary source	A source that reports on, analyzes, summarizes, or comments on primary material.
Tertiary source	A source that compiles or indexes other sources, such as a directory or encyclopedia.
Source chain	The sequence through which information passes from its origin to later republications.
Attribution chain	The explicit sequence of credits or citations showing where material or claims came from.
Citation chain	The reference path through which a later claim points to an earlier source.
Citation cascade	Many pages repeat a claim that ultimately derives from a single origin.
Circular sourcing	Sources cite one another so a claim looks independently confirmed even though none supplies original evidence.
Citation laundering	Repetition through nominally separate sources that disguises a claim's single, weak, or interested origin.
Source laundering	Passing self-interested material through intermediaries so it appears independent.
Claim laundering	Restating a claim in increasingly authoritative language without improving its evidence base.
Context collapse	Removing caveats, conditions, dates, scope, or uncertainty until a modest source claim becomes sweeping.
Quote mining	Extracting words from a source while obscuring surrounding context in a way that changes the apparent meaning.
Boilerplate fingerprinting	Comparing repeated bios, phrases, quotes, contact blocks, or formatting to identify shared origin or coordination.
Textual similarity analysis	Comparing documents to detect copied, spun, or syndicated material.
Reverse image search	Finding previous appearances of an image to assess source, date, and context.
Archive verification	Using a preserved capture to establish what a page showed at an earlier date.
Web archiving	Preserving websites, pages, files, or social material for historical reference and research.
Timestamp triangulation	Comparing publication dates, archive dates, metadata, social posts, and index timing to reconstruct sequence.
Byline verification	Checking whether a named writer has a real, consistent body of work and relationship to the publication.
Masthead verification	Checking an outlet's owners, editors, contributors, policies, contacts, and publishing history.

Domain provenance	Investigating a domain's ownership, history, acquisitions, redirects, or prior use.
WHOIS history	Historical registration and ownership information for a domain, where available.
Passive DNS	Historical data about domain, subdomain, and IP associations; useful context but not independent proof of authorship or intent.
Infrastructure overlap	Shared hosting, analytics IDs, templates, tags, contacts, or DNS patterns across apparently separate sites.
Network analysis	Mapping connections among people, domains, links, social accounts, citations, and technical infrastructure.
Attribution confidence	The degree of certainty that a specific actor created, controlled, paid for, or benefited from a page or campaign.
False attribution risk	The danger of assigning authorship or intent too strongly from circumstantial signals.
Lead versus evidence	A search snippet, listing, or suspicious URL is a lead; direct live-page or archived verification is evidence.

Manipulation, Reviews, and Deceptive Marketing

Review fraud	Fabricating, buying, selling, or procuring reviews that falsely represent genuine customer experience.
Review farm	A vendor or coordinated network selling reviews, ratings, likes, follows, installs, or other engagement.
Astroturfing	Manufacturing the appearance of independent grassroots support through coordinated posts, comments, endorsements, petitions, or reviews.
Sockpuppeting	Using fabricated or undisclosed alternate identities to praise, defend, attack, or steer a discussion.
Meatpuppeting	Recruiting real people to act on an organizer's agenda without transparent disclosure of the organizing relationship.
Shilling	Covert promotion by someone with an undisclosed stake in the seller, product, or outcome.
Endorsement laundering	Making paid, insider, or biased endorsement appear to be independent third-party validation.
Undisclosed material connection	A hidden relationship—payment, affiliate status, employment, family link, free product—that could affect how audiences assess an endorsement.
Fake scarcity	Inventing or perpetually resetting limits on stock, time, seats, demand, or eligibility.
Fake social proof	Fabricated popularity signals such as bought followers, fake purchases, invented logos, or false user counts.
Testimonial laundering	Reusing, editing, or repositioning a statement to imply endorsement or results beyond what the speaker actually said.
Negative-review suppression	Deleting, threatening, gating, selectively soliciting, or otherwise suppressing unfavorable reviews to create a falsely positive picture.
Dark patterns	Design practices that trick, steer, or manipulate users into choices they might not otherwise make.
Roach motel	Easy enrollment or sign-up paired with disproportionately difficult cancellation.
Forced action	Requiring an unnecessary step such as account creation, permission grant, or app download to do something basic.
Confirmshaming	Using guilt or shame wording to discourage a user from declining an offer.
Misdirection	Drawing attention to the seller-preferred choice while obscuring alternatives.
Sneak into basket	Adding a product, warranty, donation, subscription, or fee to a cart without clear active selection.
Hidden costs	Fees appearing only after a user has invested time or reached late checkout.
Hidden subscription	A free, discounted, or one-time offer quietly converting into recurring charges.
Forced continuity	A trial, sample, or low-cost offer converting automatically unless the consumer cancels.
Negative option	A model where silence or failure to cancel is treated as agreement to continued charges or an offer.
Trick question	Confusing double negatives or loaded phrasing that causes accidental agreement.
Privacy Zuckering	Pressuring or tricking people into sharing more personal data than intended.

Obstruction	Deliberate extra steps between a user and cancellation, refund, opt-out, or privacy controls.
Nagging	Repeated prompts after a person has already declined.
Interface interference	Manipulative hierarchy, wording, contrast, defaults, or layout that makes one choice materially harder.
Preselection	Checking boxes or enabling add-ons by default.
Bundled consent	Treating agreement to unrelated data uses or terms as a single all-or-nothing choice.
Cookie-wall coercion	Blocking access unless a user accepts data practices beyond what is necessary to provide the service.
Asymmetric friction	One choice is fast and easy while a consumer-protective alternative is slow, confusing, or hidden.
False hierarchy	Making an optional choice look mandatory or authoritative through layout or design.
Click fatigue	Wearing people down with repeated dialogs and prompts until they accept.
Cancellation maze	A multi-step, multi-channel, or time-limited cancellation process designed to induce abandonment.
Dark default	A default setting that favors data collection, recurring billing, disclosure, or engagement over likely user preference.
Deceptive pattern	Broad term for a transaction or interface design that produces a misleading or manipulative result.

Funnel, Pricing, and Sales Psychology

Problem–agitate–solution (PAS)	A copywriting structure that names a pain point, intensifies its emotional cost, then presents an offer as relief.
Fear, uncertainty, and doubt (FUD)	Messaging intended to create anxiety or indecision that makes a prescribed product, expert, or position seem necessary.
Loss aversion exploitation	Framing an offer around avoiding loss because losses feel especially urgent.
Hope marketing	Selling a vivid desired future while offering weak evidence that the product can deliver it.
Pain-point mining	Identifying recurring fears, embarrassments, or frustrations in a group and converting them into targeted marketing angles.
Identity marketing	Making purchase or affiliation signal who the buyer is or aspires to be.
Status anxiety marketing	Selling relief from fears of mediocrity, exclusion, being behind, or lack of recognition.
Moral licensing	Framing a purchase as virtuous so skepticism feels selfish or disloyal.
Reciprocity hook	Giving a free resource, audit, report, or consultation to create later purchase pressure.
Foot-in-the-door	A small initial commitment used to increase the likelihood of larger commitments later.
Door-in-the-face	Opening with an extreme request and then presenting the intended smaller request as a concession.
Lowballing	Gaining agreement before revealing material unfavorable terms, effort, or costs.
Decoy effect	Introducing an inferior option so a preferred option appears more attractive.
Price anchoring	Presenting a high reference price so a target price appears like a bargain.
Partitioned pricing	Breaking one price into components to make the headline price appear lower.
Drip pricing	Revealing unavoidable charges gradually during the buying process.
Obscure pricing	Using vague credits, tokens, usage units, tiers, or rules that make the real cost hard to calculate.
Price discrimination	Charging different customers different prices based on segment, behavior, location, or willingness to pay.
Price framing	Using “per day,” “less than coffee,” or monthly equivalents to obscure a larger total commitment.
Breakage model	Profiting because customers fail to redeem credits, rebates, points, benefits, or gift cards.

Sludge	Friction deliberately inserted to discourage people from claiming a benefit, canceling, or completing a task.
Choice architecture	The design of how options are presented; neutral in itself.
Manipulative choice architecture	Arranging defaults, timing, visual weight, and language to steer people away from their real preference.
Nudge laundering	Calling coercive or deceptive tactics harmless “nudges” to sanitize manipulation.
Consent theater	Legal-looking consent rituals that do not create meaningful comprehension or genuine choice.
Lead-generation arbitrage	Buying cheap attention or search traffic, collecting leads, and reselling them to providers; deceptive if the intermediary poses as the direct provider.
Rank-and-rent	Building a local SEO asset, generating leads, then leasing the leads or site to a business.
Local lead-gen impersonation	A lead-generation site falsely presenting itself as an established local provider.
Bait-and-switch	Advertising one offer, price, product, or capability to attract someone and steering them to a materially different one.
Tripwire funnel	A low-cost opening offer designed to turn a prospect into a buyer and enable later upsells.
Disguised ad	Promotional material designed to resemble editorial content, a system notice, a download button, or an independent recommendation.
Presell page	Article-style material designed to warm a visitor before sending them to an offer.
Faux authority	Manufacturing perceived expertise through invented credentials, vague titles, purchased awards, or false affiliations.

Claims, Evidence, and Institutional Theater

Claim laundering	Repeating or reformatting a claim until it seems established despite weak or absent original evidence.
Evidence laundering	Turning low-quality, irrelevant, preliminary, or self-interested evidence into the appearance of strong proof.
Science-washing	Using scientific imagery, terminology, citations, lab aesthetics, or tiny studies to give unsupported claims scientific sheen.
Health-washing	Creating an impression of wellness, safety, naturalness, or therapeutic value beyond the evidence.
Greenwashing	Overstating, obscuring, or inventing environmental responsibility.
Ethics-washing	Using mission language, charity, or ethical commitments to distract from harmful conduct.
AI-washing	Inflating routine automation, analytics, or outsourced human labor into a proprietary AI capability.
Innovation theater	Performing visible innovation through labs, launches, councils, or hackathons without meaningful underlying change.
Transparency theater	Publishing reports, policies, dashboards, or explanations that look candid while omitting key facts.
Compliance theater	Using badges, cookie banners, certificates, and generic policies as a performance rather than actual compliance.
Security theater	Visible rituals that make people feel secure without improving protection proportionately.
Tokenism	A superficial inclusion gesture used to imply real representation or reform.
Pseudoexpertise	The performance of expert authority without corresponding qualifications, method, or accountability.
Cargo-cult science	Copying outward signals of science—charts, jargon, white coats, studies—without genuine rigor or falsifiability.
Technobabble	Impressive-sounding technical language designed to overawe rather than clarify.
Quantwashing	Using numbers, rankings, dashboards, and precision to make a weak conclusion feel objective.
Precision theater	Giving overly exact figures without explaining methods, data, or uncertainty.
Cherry-picking	Selecting only supportive evidence while omitting contrary evidence or the full body of research.
Surrogate metric	A convenient proxy such as impressions, followers, downloads, or mentions promoted as if it proves quality or impact.

Credential laundering	Presenting weak, self-created, irrelevant, or unverified qualifications as authority.
Association laundering	Implying a meaningful relationship with an institution, celebrity, regulator, university, or organization that is weak, expired, paid, or nonexistent.
Digital credentialing	The legitimate creation of verifiable records of releases, credits, affiliations, performances, and work history.

Fraud and Con Anatomy

Confidence game / con	A fraud based on deliberately cultivated trust rather than overt force.
Long con	A prolonged relationship-driven operation with staged escalation and compounding trust.
Short con	A fast opportunistic swindle that relies on urgency and limited verification.
Grift	Informal term for a dishonest scheme monetizing attention, charm, ideology, or vague promises.
Mark	Con-artist jargon for the intended target or victim.
Ringer	A planted insider who appears to be an ordinary buyer, bidder, customer, winner, or participant.
Inside man	An accomplice positioned to appear independent or authoritative.
Front person	A public-facing figure used to conceal the actual operator, owner, or beneficiary.
Cutout	An intermediary used to conceal a principal's involvement or create plausible deniability.
Money mule	Someone who receives or transfers fraud proceeds, knowingly or unknowingly.
Straw buyer	A person making a purchase, loan application, account opening, or transaction for the real beneficiary.
Drop account	A disposable bank, crypto, marketplace, mail, or social account used to receive or route illicit proceeds or goods.
Bust-out	Building credit, trust, inventory access, or account history legitimately and then maximizing extraction before disappearing.
Exit scam	Collecting deposits, investments, purchases, or subscriptions and vanishing before delivery.
Advance-fee fraud	Demanding upfront payment to unlock a promised loan, grant, prize, inheritance, job, recovery, or benefit.
419 scam	A classic advance-fee fraud historically associated with large-transfer or inheritance stories.
Recovery scam	Targeting prior victims with false promises to recover money, restore accounts, or retrieve assets for a fee.
Double dipping	Monetizing the same victim multiple times, directly or by reselling victim data.
Reload scam	Recontacting a prior victim for another payment under a new pretext.
Pig butchering	Long-duration relationship and investment fraud that cultivates trust and escalates deposits before extraction.
Affinity fraud	Exploiting shared religion, profession, identity, community, fandom, or neighborhood to establish trust.
Romance scam	A fabricated intimate relationship used to obtain money, data, or access.
Imposter scam	Pretending to be a trusted person, company, agency, bank, delivery service, or authority.
Pretexting	Using a fabricated scenario or identity to obtain information, money, access, or cooperation.
Social engineering	Manipulating trust, authority, fear, urgency, curiosity, or helpfulness to bypass safeguards.
Phishing	Deceptive communications designed to steal credentials, money, or sensitive information.
Spear phishing	Phishing tailored to a specific person, organization, or role.
Whaling	Spear phishing aimed at executives or high-value targets.
Smishing	Phishing by SMS or messaging app.
Vishing	Phishing by voice call or voicemail.
Quishing	Phishing through QR codes.

Business email compromise (BEC)	Account compromise or impersonation used to redirect payments or induce unauthorized transfers.
Invoice fraud	Fake, altered, duplicate, or redirected invoices used to obtain payment.
Vendor impersonation	Posing as a real supplier or contractor to alter payment details or obtain funds.
Account takeover (ATO)	Taking control of a real account using stolen credentials, social engineering, SIM swaps, or session theft.
SIM swapping	Fraudulently transferring a phone number to an attacker's SIM to intercept codes and recover accounts.
Synthetic identity fraud	Combining real and fabricated personal data to build a new identity for accounts or credit.
Friendly fraud	A buyer falsely disputes a legitimate transaction as unauthorized or undelivered.
Triangulation fraud	Taking an order from a buyer, using stolen payment credentials to source the item, and retaining the buyer's payment.
Refund fraud	Illegitimately obtaining refunds, chargebacks, returns, or replacements.
Card testing	Using small transactions to see whether stolen payment credentials work.
Carding	The broader trafficking or use of stolen payment-card data.
Chargeback fraud	Abusing payment disputes to reverse valid transactions.

Corporate Opacity and Accountability

Shell company	A legal entity with little independent operation; it can be lawful but may be used to obscure ownership or transactions.
Front company	A seemingly ordinary business used to conceal illicit, fraudulent, or unrelated activity.
Nominee director / nominee owner	A listed officer or owner who may stand in for a hidden controller or beneficial owner.
Beneficial owner	The person who ultimately owns, controls, or receives economic benefit from an entity.
Layering	Moving money through multiple accounts, entities, platforms, or transactions to obscure source and destination.
Commingling	Mixing personal, business, client, investor, or illicit funds so ownership and accountability are harder to trace.
Pass-through entity	An entity that primarily receives and transfers money or rights onward; it may be legitimate administration or an opacity device.
Merchant-of-record laundering	Using another entity in the payment chain so card statements, refunds, taxes, or disputes point away from the real operator.
Payment descriptor laundering	Using a vague, unrelated, or benign card-statement descriptor to conceal what was purchased.
White-labeling	One company provides a product or service that another brand resells as its own; legitimate unless it misrepresents expertise or capability.
Agency laundering	Attributing controversial marketing, lead generation, content, or outreach to a contractor while retaining direction or benefit.
Franchise laundering	Using franchise-like structures to diffuse responsibility while centrally controlling the customer experience.
Jurisdiction shopping / regulatory arbitrage	Choosing corporate, payment, hosting, licensing, or legal jurisdictions for weaker oversight or lower accountability.
Forum-selection trap	Burying a term requiring disputes to be brought in a distant or burdensome jurisdiction.
Arbitration laundering	Using mandatory arbitration, confidentiality, and individualized proceedings to reduce public visibility of recurring disputes.
Phoenix company	A business that collapses under claims or debts and reappears under a new name with similar operators, assets, or practices.
Brand cycling	Repeatedly launching, burning, and replacing brands to outrun negative reviews, chargebacks, enforcement, or search results.

Reputation laundering through rebranding	Changing a company name, domain, founder story, or public identity to distance it from prior conduct.
Domain churn	Continually rotating domains, landing pages, subdomains, and ad accounts to evade takedowns or obscure history.
KYC evasion	Bypassing identity verification through stolen identities, mules, synthetic identities, shell structures, or false documents.

Education, Authorship, and Credentials

Diploma mill / degree mill	An entity that sells academic-looking degrees with little meaningful instruction, assessment, or academic standards.
Accreditation mill	A fake or weak accreditor used to give diploma mills an appearance of legitimacy.
Credential mill	A broader category of entities selling certificates, badges, qualifications, or designations without meaningful training or verification.
Paper mill / essay mill	A service selling academic assignments, dissertations, or research papers for submission as someone else's work.
Ghostwriting	Writing credited to someone else; normal in some creative and professional contexts, deceptive when used to misrepresent authorship or expertise.
Ghost management	Undisclosed third-party operation of an expert's, executive's, or creator's social accounts.
Ghost-produced expert	A public authority whose content, books, courses, or sales material is largely produced by undisclosed contractors while marketed as sole expertise.
Resume fraud	Falsifying employment history, education, qualifications, titles, certifications, references, or accomplishments.
Title inflation	Using grand titles that imply responsibility or qualification not reflected in the actual role.
Authority cue exploitation	Using credentials, uniforms, logos, legalistic language, experts, or official-looking sites to induce trust or compliance.

Fast Distinction Guide

Astroturfing	Fake grassroots consensus.
Shilling	Covert promotion by a person with a stake.
Sockpuppeting	A fake or undisclosed alternate identity used to influence perception.
Review fraud	Fake or deceptive customer feedback specifically.
Information laundering	Disguising the actual origin of a claim through intermediaries and repetition.
Authority laundering	Disguising the absence of real validation by borrowing prestigious signals.
Cloaking	Deceiving search engines about what a page contains.
Bait-and-switch	Deceiving prospective buyers about the offer or terms.
Dark patterns	Manipulating choice through design, defaults, friction, and interface structure.
Ghostwriting	Neutral by itself; deception occurs when hidden authorship is used to misrepresent expertise or accomplishment.
Visibility	Being easy to find.
Notability	Being independently recognized as culturally, professionally, or historically meaningful.
Search residue	A discoverable trace, not proof of endorsement, authorship, affiliation, or credible publication coverage.

Practical Audit Questions

For an apparent press mention: Who originated it? Is there a named author? Does the article add reporting, independent quotes, analysis, criticism, or distinct framing? Is it labeled sponsored, partner content, or a press release?

For a sudden flood of URLs: Did they appear within hours or on the same day? Is the text identical? Do they trace to a feed, wire service, RSS source, or one announcement?

For a claimed credential or affiliation: Can the school, award, institution, publication, or professional body be verified independently? What exactly was awarded, purchased, or approved?

For a suspicious SEO page: Does it contain unrelated keywords, thin or gibberish text, hidden redirects, a compromised domain, copied material, or a funnel to another destination? Treat snippets as leads until verified on a live or archived page.

For an ethical independent-artist presence: Keep an official source-of-truth site; normalize names and links; maintain accurate distribution metadata; separate official announcements from independent coverage; use transparent labels for sponsored work; preserve credits and archives.

Selected Source Concepts

This guide consolidates terminology discussed in the conversation. For policy-grounded search vocabulary, Google Search Central uses terms including canonicalization, structured data, expired-domain abuse, site-reputation abuse, and scaled content abuse. U.S. consumer-protection vocabulary includes fake reviews and testimonials, deceptive design or “dark patterns,” and negative-option marketing. The terminology here also includes industry, media-studies, cybersecurity, OSINT, and informal analytical usage; terminology and legal definitions vary by jurisdiction and context.